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Problem Statement

- Social isolation is a significant public health concern among college students because it affects mental health, academic performance, and overall well-being.
- First-year undergraduate students at the University of St. Thomas are especially affected due to the transition into a new academic and social environment.
- Many students experience loneliness as they adjust to campus life, build new relationships, and manage increased academic expectations.
- National data show that a large proportion of college students report feeling overwhelmed, emotionally exhausted, and disconnected during the academic year.
- Factors such as limited social networks, academic pressure, and reduced opportunities for engagement contribute to this issue.
- Without early support, social isolation can lead to increased stress, anxiety, depression, and unhealthy coping behaviors such as substance use.
- The FYEX Connection Program and First-Year Connectors aim to address this problem by creating structured opportunities for peer connection, support, and engagement during students’ transition into college.

Literature Review Summary

- Social isolation is strongly associated with poor mental health outcomes in college students, including increased depression, anxiety, and stress (1, 2).
- First-year and transitioning students are especially vulnerable due to new environments, limited established social networks, and increased academic pressure (1).
- National and local data (NCHA; UMN CSHS) show high rates of loneliness, emotional exhaustion, and moderate-to-severe anxiety/depression among undergraduate students.
- Limited social support is linked to unhealthy coping behaviors, including substance use, and lower overall well-being (2).
- Strong peer relationships and a sense of belonging are associated with improved mental health, academic adjustment, and student retention (2, 3).
- Peer-led interventions reduce stigma, increase help-seeking behavior, and strengthen social connectedness among college students (3, 4).
- Structured group-based interventions demonstrate reductions in loneliness and improvements in mood, engagement, and stress levels (5).
- Digital and structured interventions can increase perceived social support and reduce loneliness over time (1).
- Group-based, person-centered approaches improve social connectedness and overall well-being across populations (6).
- Overall, the literature supports peer-led, structured engagement programs (such as FYEX-style initiatives) as effective strategies for reducing social isolation and improving undergraduate student mental health outcomes.

Data Brief

Figure 1: Comparison of Social Isolation Among Local (Minnesota Undergrads) vs. National

Undergraduate Students			
Measure	UMN Twin Cities (%)	National Benchmark (%)	Difference (%)
Frequent Social Isolation	34.2	28	+6.2
Moderate-to-Severe Anxiety	31.5	34	-2.5
Moderate-to-Severe Depression	36.7	32	+4.7

- The figure was created using data from the Fall 2025 National College Health Assessment and the 2024 University of Minnesota College Student Health Survey.
- Minnesota college students report higher levels of frequent social isolation (34.2%) compared to the national average (28.0%) (7, 8).
- Minnesota college students report higher rates of moderate-to-severe depression (36.7%) compared to the national average (34.0%) (7, 8).
- Minnesota college students report slightly lower rates of moderate-to-severe anxiety (31.5%) compared to the national average (34.0%) (7, 8).
- Overall, the data indicates that Minnesota college students experience frequent social isolation at higher rates than students nationally.
- These findings suggest a significant disparity in social isolation and mental health outcomes within the broader Minnesota college student population.

Primary Data Collection

- A survey was chosen as the primary data collection tool because it allows us to effectively reach a wide range of undergraduate students, including those who may be experiencing higher levels of social isolation.
- Surveys provide a low-pressure, private, and self-paced way for students to respond, which is especially important when discussing sensitive topics like loneliness and mental health.
- The survey includes questions about students’ demographics, campus experiences, and use of campus resources to understand how engagement relates to belonging.
- It also includes the UCLA Loneliness Scale, a validated tool used to measure feelings of loneliness and social isolation (9).
- Combining these questions helps us connect students’ campus involvement, how students engaged with campus resources and organizations, with their perceived level of social isolation.
- The survey method allows for efficient, accessible, and meaningful data collection to better understand social isolation among University of St. Thomas students.

Program Proposal

- The FYEX Connection Program is a peer-led, course-embedded initiative designed to reduce social isolation and strengthen belonging among first-year students at the University of St. Thomas.
- The program integrates trained upperclassmen “First-Year Connectors” (FYCs) into First-Year Experience (FYEX) seminars to facilitate structured social connection, movement-based activities, and peer mentorship within required coursework.
- The program framework includes small group sessions led by FYCs, weekly in-class community-building sessions, one required out-of-class group activity, a community engagement/service-learning requirement, and a 1:1 holistic check-in with each student.
- A digital component (Canvas reflections and group messaging) supports ongoing engagement and reinforces connection outside of class.
- By embedding structured peer relationships directly into a required academic course, the program ensures equitable access to social support and encourages sustainable social connection-building habits.
- The program addresses first-year isolation at the point of highest need, promoting long-term student well-being and campus engagement.

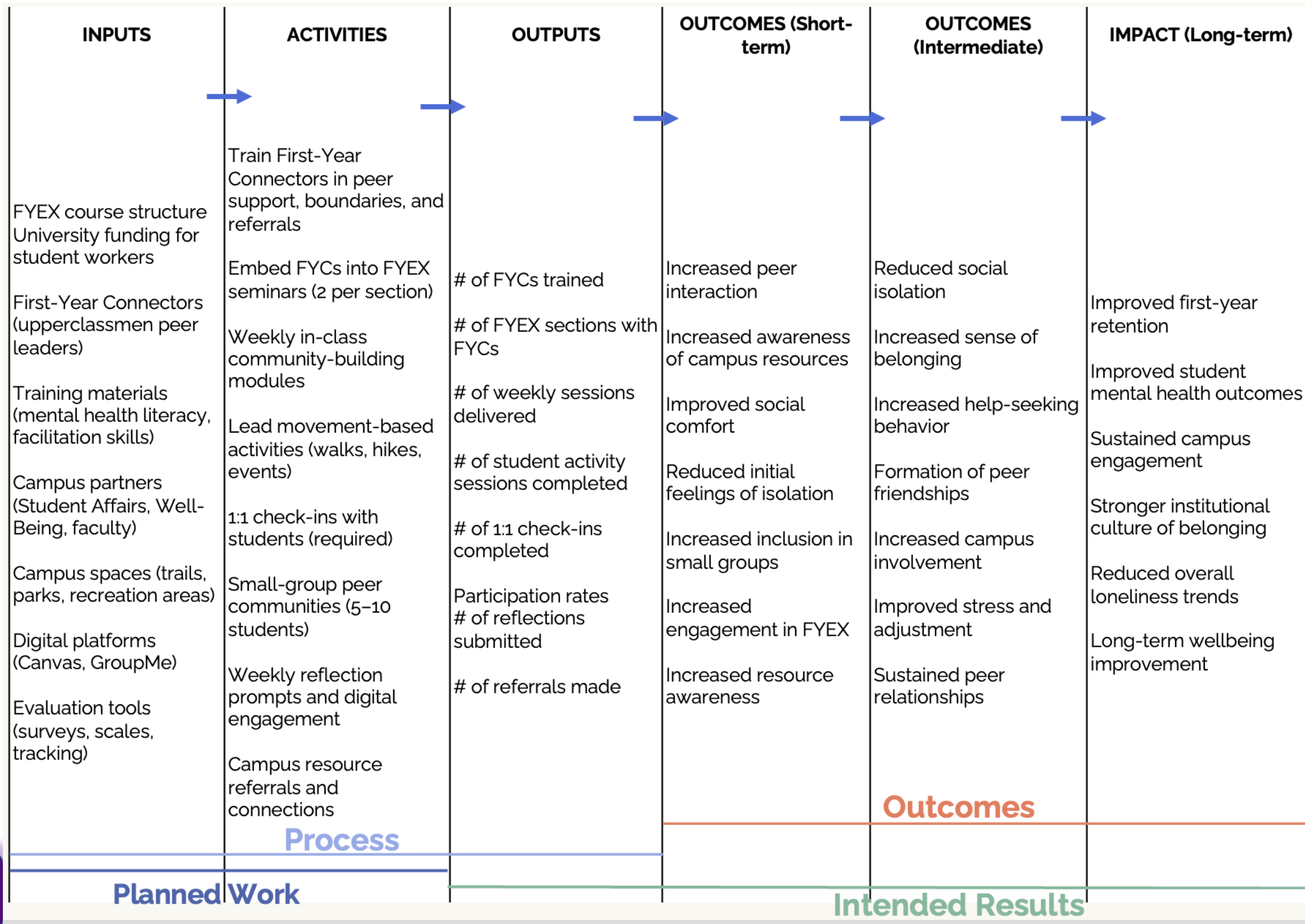


Figure 2. Logic Model for FYEX Connection & First-Year Connectors Program

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Thank you!

Thank you to Dr. Jenny Kluznik, Dr. Amy Hedman-Robertson, and all professors in the Public Health Department at the University of St. Thomas.